It is an article of faith among the American and British security establishments that Lashkar has acted as a gateway to al-Qaeda on numerous occasions, providing indoctrination, networking opportunities, safe haven or other forms of facilitation to aspiring jihadis like Siddique Khan and Tanweer. However, it must be noted that the group was viewed as a partner in a consortium with al-Qaeda rather than a contractor which made potentially valuable operatives available.[195] Members of the Pakistani diaspora were (and remain) particularly well placed to use what has been termed the 'Kashmir Escalator,' namely the process by which members of the diaspora were radicalized at home and then traveled to Pakistan, where they initially connected with current or previously Kashmir-centric militant groups—primarily Lashkar or Jaish. Some exploited familial and friendship ties in Pakistan to make these initial contacts; others took advantage of the international networks both groups initially built to support the Kashmir jihad. Once in Pakistan, would-be jihadis exploited grassroots connections among foot soldiers as well as organizational linkages to access al-Qaeda operatives in the Tribal Areas. Some of them later reappeared in the West to launch terrorist attacks while others stayed in Pakistan planning or otherwise supporting such attacks.[196]

Those arriving in Pakistan often took advantage of Lashkar's above-ground infrastructure, which remained legal. The group's offices and madaris are considered to have become a first port of call after 9/11, though these were not the only entry point. For example, several of the British men involved in the thwarted al-Qaeda plot to use liquid explosives to bomb transatlantic airlines flights en route from the UK to North America in 2006 worked in JuD relief camps after the October 2005 earthquake. From there they are believed to have moved on to training camps in Waziristan.[197] British investigators also suspected that Lashkar funneled some of the money raised for earthquake relief to plotters of the attempted attack.[198] Its operatives in Britain reportedly provided money for the plane tickets used to conduct a practice run as well as for the attacks themselves.[199] This use of Lashkar's networks to provide direct financial or operational support for terrorist attacks constitutes yet another means by which it contributed to the global jihad after 9/11. It is to these activities that we now turn.

Participating in Terrorist Attacks